the ibadat khana, it was as though he had been freed from an earlier adherence to orthodoxy. Badauni had written that since the ulema constantly contradicted each other, and would use fallacious arguments to first support, and then disprove the very same beliefs, Akbar's faith was shaken. And just as he had once believed with devotion everything they said, now that that faith had cracked 'he inferred the known from the known and rejected also their predecessors'. Where orthodox Islam was found wanting, Akbar turned for answers to more mystical alternatives within Islam and then to the different religions in his wide kingdom. Badauni had noted with sadness that 'everything that pleased him, he picked and chose from, anyone except a Moslem, and anything that was against his disposition and ran counter to his wishes, he thought fit to reject and cast aside'.

There were a number of subterranean streams of thinking in the sixteenth century that contributed to Akbar's religious experimentation and much scholarly work has been done on the subject. There was the Sufi belief in 'Unity in Multiplicity' known as Wahdat-al-Wujud, which Akbar had long known through the Chishti Sufis and which allowed for a great deal of flexibility and cultural pluralism. There was the doctrine of the 'Unity of Existence' present in medieval Islam through the work of Ibn Arabi and the theory of 'Divine Light' of Shihab al-Din Suhrawardi Maqtul, all of which Akbar would have heard about through Shaikh Mubarak and Abu'l Fazl. There was also the Nirguna Bhakti of the Bhakti saints such as Kabir, who saw no difference between Hindus and Muslims, and whose incandescent teachings raged through the Braj heartland.

In all that he heard and saw around him, Akbar seemed to adopt only that which he could physically and viscerally experience and shape. This was entirely in character and he behaved just as he did in all other facets of his life, when he was seen making ribbons like a lace-maker, and filing, sawing, hewing, polishing and quarrying, always needing to experience the world directly.

In his quest for spiritual truths he prostrated himself in front of many gods—he prayed to the sun, he whispered mantras, he worshipped fire, he kept fasts, and he examined his conscience. And in his own manner, every assertion he came across Akbar would now submit to the test of reason or, as Abu'l Fazl put it, 'intellect (khirad)' would be elevated to a 'high pedestal (buland paigi)'. Now aql (reason) would be praised above mere